# Day 5 — The Doṣa Day-Clock

**Module:** Doṣas · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

## Learning objective

By the end of this lesson, students name the six 4-hour windows of the *doṣa* day-clock with their dominant *doṣa*, explain *why* each *doṣa* dominates at that time, and connect this to one modern observation about circadian biology.

## Materials

- Large clock-face diagram on the board, divided into 6 four-hour windows
- Coloured chalk / markers (one per *doṣa*)
- Printed copy of the day-clock for each student

## Vocabulary introduced today

- *kāla* (IAST: kāla; lit. "time") — used in Ayurveda as "the time-of-day factor" in determining how the *doṣa*s behave.

## Lesson flow

### Warm-up (5 min)

- *"At what time of day do you feel most alert?"* — quick show of hands.
- *"At what time do you feel most slow / sleepy?"*
- *"Today we ask: is this random, or is there a pattern?"*

### Core (20 min)

1. **Build the clock on the board.** Draw a 24-hour clock face. Divide into six 4-hour wedges. Label each with start-end time. Then assign each window its dominant *doṣa* (colour-coded):

| Window | Time | Dominant doṣa | Why |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 6 am – 10 am | *kapha* | Body is heavy, slow to start — heavy mucus, deep tissue. Best for solid breakfast, mild exercise. |

| Window | Time | Dominant doṣa | Why |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2 | 10 am – 2 pm | *pitta* | Digestive fire peaks at noon. Best for the main meal of the day. |
| 3 | 2 pm – 6 pm | *vāta* | Energy is bursty, mind active, body lighter. Best for focused work, short snacks. |
| 4 | 6 pm – 10 pm | *kapha* | Body slows for sleep. Best for light dinner, calming activity. |
| 5 | 10 pm – 2 am | *pitta* | Body's deep repair (liver, metabolism). Best for actual sleep — don't snack now. |
| 6 | 2 am – 6 am | *vāta* | Light sleep, dreams; body cycles toward waking. Wake at end of window. |

*"Each doṣa shows up twice — once during the day, once at night."*

2. **The classical principle.** Source paraphrase:

   "The doṣas have their own times — kapha in the morning and early night, pitta at midday and midnight, vāta in the afternoon and pre-dawn." — paraphrased from Aṣṭāṅga Hṛdaya, *Sūtrasthāna* 1 (Vāgbhaṭa)
3. **Why this matters in practice (Ayurveda's claim):**
   - Heavy meal at *kapha* time (6–10 pm) sits heavy and disrupts sleep.
   - Heavy meal at *pitta* time (10 am – 2 pm) digests well.
   - Trying to sleep deeply at *vāta* time (2–6 am) is hard — that's why you wake at 4 am even if you went to bed late.
   - Skipping the *kapha* morning window (sleeping in until 11 am) leaves you groggy — the body needed to wake before the kapha window closed.
4. **The modern parallel — chronobiology** (state, don't overstate):
   - Modern science: the body has a **circadian rhythm** controlled by the suprachiasmatic nucleus in the brain, driven by light exposure.
   - Insulin sensitivity (how well you handle sugar): higher in the morning, lower at night. Big dinner late = worse glucose handling. (Real effect; see Panda 2012.)
   - Cortisol (stress hormone): peaks ~6–8 am, drops through the day. That's why morning is mentally "harder to start" if you slept badly.
   - Body temperature: lowest around 4–5 am, peaks late afternoon. Matches *vāta* time roughly.

   **The honest framing:** the *general principle* (the body cycles through the day) is robust modern science. The *specific doṣa-clock windows* are an Ayurvedic codification — not a 1:1 match with modern timing studies, but a workable approximation.

### Activity (15 min) — Map your day

- Hand out the printed day-clock.
- Students annotate it with what they actually do at each window. (Wake 6:30, brush teeth, breakfast 7:30, school 8:30, lunch 12:30, etc.)
- For each entry, ask: *"Is this activity matched to the dominant doṣa at this time?"*
  - Heavy lunch at noon (pitta time) — matched.
  - Heavy dinner at 9 pm (kapha time) — mismatched.
  - Heavy nap at 3 pm (vāta time) — mismatched.
- Each student picks ONE mismatch and writes a one-line *what would I change?*

### Wrap-up (5 min)

- **Formative quiz, Part B** (5 questions, 4 min) — see `quizzes/formative.md` Part B.
- Collect.
- Preview Day 6: *"Tomorrow — the six tastes. Yes, we will taste things."*

## Student-facing content

**The doṣa day-clock:**

| Window | Time | Doṣa | Best for |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 6 am – 10 am | *kapha* | wake, light exercise, solid breakfast |
| 2 | 10 am – 2 pm | *pitta* | main meal of the day, focused work |
| 3 | 2 pm – 6 pm | *vāta* | quick work, short snacks |
| 4 | 6 pm – 10 pm | *kapha* | light dinner, wind down |
| 5 | 10 pm – 2 am | *pitta* | deep sleep (body's repair) |
| 6 | 2 am – 6 am | *vāta* | wake at the end of this window |

The principle: align activities with the dominant doṣa of the time.

— *paraphrased from Aṣṭāṅga Hṛdaya, Sūtrasthāna 1*

**Modern parallel:** chronobiology. The body has rhythms. Insulin works better in the morning. Cortisol peaks at dawn. Body temperature peaks late afternoon. The general shape matches; the exact timing doesn't precisely line up. Both frameworks point to the same underlying observation: *when* matters as much as *what*.

## Homework

- Tonight, note your bedtime. Tomorrow morning, note your wake time. Then write: which doṣa-window did each fall into? Was your sleep aligned with the recommended pattern?

## Differentiation

- **One tier up:** Look up "circadian rhythm" and write one sentence on the mechanism (light → SCN → melatonin/cortisol). How does the modern picture differ from the *doṣa*-clock?
- **One tier down:** Memorise just the three midday/midnight windows: 10–2 (day) and 10–2 (night) — both pitta. That's the spine of the clock.

## Teacher notes

- Some students will say their family's dinner is at 9 pm. Don't shame them. Note the principle; don't prescribe.
- The clock is an *idealised pattern*, not a rigid rule. Indian families dinner at all sorts of times for legitimate reasons. The point is to notice the *trade-off*, not to comply.
- Don't conflate the *doṣa* clock with the modern circadian rhythm too tightly. They overlap in spirit, not in detail.

## Citation(s) used in this lesson

- Aṣṭāṅga Hṛdaya, *Sūtrasthāna* 1 (Vāgbhaṭa) — paraphrase on *doṣa* times of day. See `sources.md`.
- Modern parallel: Panda et al. (2012) on meal-timing and glucose handling — teacher reference only; not student-facing citation.